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friendly message to the communities. This gesture had helped the party reap electoral dividends as it managed to wrest seats with the support of their respective communities.

The CPI(M) had long ago diagnosed the cause for its stagnation as its inability to make major inroads into the Muslim and Christian communities, which together form 43 per cent of the state's 3.20 crore population. In fact, much more than the political opposition, the Left's bitterest enemies in the state have been the Muslim and Christian leadership. Even the country's first-ever elected communist government of 1957, led by EMS Namboodiripad, was brought down within two years by the "Liberation Struggle" led by Christian and Muslim leaders.

Two years ago, an unseemly fight erupted when a bishop of the Syro-

Malabar Church claimed that it had performed religious funeral rites for late CPI(M) leader Mathai Chacko as per his own wishes. The CPI(M) took serious offence to it and a furious Pinarayi Vijayan, the all-powerful state secretary, even called the bishop a liar and a despised beast. Priests reacted angrily and the laity led protest meetings in all churches across the state. Later, a new school textbook introduced by the LDF Government's Education Ministry, which contained a chapter on the virtues of being not religious, had to be withdrawn following angry protests by Christians and Muslims. "Communists have always been against God and religion. They have seldom changed their stripes," snapped Archbishop Joseph Powathil, who leads the Church's anti-communist campaign. He added that Christians would be better off under

BJP rule than the communists. "The CPI(M) is the largest Hindu party in Kerala with 80 per cent of its members being Hindus," says a Christian priest. The CPI(M)'s open alliance with some "progressive" bishops and also groups within the church extolling a pro-poor "Liberation Theology" too have yielded only limited results.

The party's engagement with Hinduism too has triggered much heat and dust. The religious funeral rites observed for former chief minister E.K. Nayanar had provoked angry reactions from a section of party workers and jeers from its critics. However, powerful leaders like EMS had ignored the brickbats when he once took his religious wife to temples. "Who else should take my wife to a temple if she wants to go there?" he used to retort when quizzed about his temple visits. In West Bengal, the late CPI(M) leader Subhas Chakraborty had stunned those who criticised his praying at a Kali temple by saying he was a Hindu and also a Brahmin besides being a communist. Chakraborty had said that the CPI(M)'s stunted growth was because it did not imbibe Indian values which were fundamentally religious.

Later, the CPI(M) had resolved as a tactic not to object party workers' association with religions. The party even sent directives to cadres to get into temple and church committees so that the RSS or anti-Left Christian groups do not "hijack them". After the 2006 Assembly elections, two of its legislators—a Hindu and a Christian—took office in the name of God which was unprecedented. The CPI(M)'s open alliance with the Peoples Democratic Party, a Muslim fundamentalist organisation, in the 2006 elections had paid rich dividends in the Muslim-dominated areas.

Now, the wheel appears to have come full circle for the CPI(M) as shown in the 2009 general elections, when the Muslims and Christians once again stood firm with the UDF. So what if Pope Benedict XIV is discovering virtues in Karl Marx, a fellow German. In Kerala, the twain, it appears, shall never meet. ■